

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: THE EPISODE AS IT STANDS

Synopsis v1.0, 2026-09-01, written for Stephen after Part F closed. This is the FULL-GRAPH account: it contains the killer, the swap, the survival and the season notch, and it must never reach Fable, readers, testers or marketing as written. It synthesises premise v8.1, spine v1.4, cold open v0.4, economy model v1.1 and structure v2.2; where it disagrees with any of those, they win. A redacted reader-safe version does not exist yet; cut one from this only deliberately.

The crime underneath.

Brad Collins was the youngest of Violet Moore's four close friends: the signwriter she taught on Tuesday nights, the one she sent up the ladder she let nobody climb, the one the others thought of as her project. He was also the cleverest person in every room he sat in, and he had spent years building a way out of his small life. The way out needed a name nobody would ever look for. Three years before Violet died, a deckhand with no family, who drank at Brad's flat and kept a dry bag there, went with him to Kestrel Head after a night's drinking and never came back. The body was never found. The skipper reported him missing; the file said "drifted"; nobody ever asked where he used to drink. Brad kept his papers, rented a room four hundred miles away as a lodger in a widow's house, took his income in cash, and put his own face on no document. The exit sat unused, just in case.

Then Violet, fighting her sister over their mother's house, started calling in every debt she was owed, and the largest was Brad's: the van, the start of his business, cash, no paper. A debt follows a man who moves. Nobody chases a debt to a man who died. And a man who dies at Kestrel Head needs a grief the whole city will believe. Hers would do.

Violet had already found something. A roof leak in her unit brought down a ceiling board, and behind it was a gilded alphabet panel in a hand she couldn't place, signed with a mark that wasn't a name, hidden above her own paint racks. She carried it around town for a month asking whose hand it was. She was the best judge of lettering on the coast, she had taught Brad herself, and she was certain of exactly one thing: it was too good to be his. Then the foot bolt of her ladder came undone, and she fell, and when she looked at the bolt it had been unscrewed, not sheared. She told no one. She had four keys cut to her storage cage at the fish market, wrote four letters and a fifth, hid the panel behind the cage door, and lodged the letters with her solicitor: post these after my funeral.

On a Monday night Brad walked to her house about the money, followed her up the stairs, and pushed once. The coroner, competently, recorded an accident.

The keys.

Two weeks later, four keys arrived in the post with letters in Violet's handwriting: *I think one of you is planning to kill me. I don't know which, and I may be wrong. Don't go to the police, and here is why. What I found is behind this door.* The four rang each other that night and agreed nobody would go alone; the first day all four could stand at the cage together was Saturday. Brad went Wednesday. He read her letter, took the panel, and spent two nights at her own bench, with her pen, her paper, and her debt book for her handwriting, writing a different letter: one that said *I know*, and laid out claims that were almost all true. Liam's secret

third of the boatyard, true. The tin of cash, true. Only the money's source was a lie: the letter said it was Liam's hush money, when it was Violet's inheritance from her mother, a secret she had told exactly one person. Beside the letter, Brad left the boat name board from Violet's hall, Liam's gift from the yard, and gave it a meaning it never had.

The room.

For weeks the four met at Ruby's kitchen table and worked a dead woman's letter. It leaned toward Liam, and every time it wavered, Brad defended him, reasonably, and lost, and the reading came back harder. Margo, the accountant, the one person who knew where Violet's money really came from, saw on the first Saturday that the letter didn't square, and said nothing, because the money was a dead friend's confidence, because Violet lied fluently about small things, and because an accusation names nobody. She kept that silence six weeks. It is the one lock the whole episode stands on. When her sums finally settled, she stopped arguing with Brad and stopped looking at the other two, and Brad read her silence for what it was. Days later his van was found at Kestrel Head, his phone on the seat, his watch smashed on the rocks. Police searched, took a DNA sample from his flat to identify a future body, and stood down. Ruby, who loved him, drove the reading on until it landed on Liam.

Five months later a stranger began speaking to Margo on the encrypted app she had used for eleven years for Tessa, the partner nobody in Havenbay knew existed. He knew things nobody had said aloud. He offered her the only story she could live inside, and when she wouldn't take it, he named a meeting: Friday, the point, eleven. Brad rode four hundred miles on cash, walked nineteen miles of ridge path, took her phone from her hand, and pushed. Margo's body came into the harbour; her death read as the guilt everyone already believed she carried. Liam and Ruby each walked into a police station within the week and said the same thing: *I'm afraid of the other one*. The police looked, properly, for six weeks. The letters were examined and passed. They found nothing, because nothing was where they looked. Then Ruby talked to the Gazette, and the front page put the four friends of Violet Moore into every kitchen in the country.

The episode the player plays.

Ally comes to it after all of it, and her ten chapters are her ten broadcast weeks. She starts with the paper, a sergeant who says *we looked, properly, there's nothing*, and Ruby willing to talk. The player merges evidence to fulfil lead packages, and each fulfilment pays a beat: Ruby's kitchen and the boxes; the café owner remembering Violet calling her money in, and carrying a gold panel round town asking whose hand made it; Liam's side, and the fishmonger's tip that the dead man visited the cage three days early, which goes to Del and never on air. A listener re-measures the man seen in Violet's lane and rules Liam out. Tessa's kept screenshot: *the thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that*. The certainty gap: dead women don't get surer. Then the question no one can answer: nobody alive ever saw Brad write. The skipper's letter about a deckhand who vanished three years too early. A woman from a platform: wet boots and a cash ticket on the first train the morning Brad's van was found. Ally stops saying "was."

Along the way the player makes four decisions: whether Ruby's letter airs whole; whether the fishmonger's tip goes straight to Del; whether Margo's words air verbatim or Tessa's channel gets shielded, which forks the evidence they build; and, at the climax, whether the panel's strange little mark airs or is held at Del's request, which forks the entire final week: a public record full of noise, or a clean identification.

Because four hundred miles away a landlady has been listening for six weeks to strangers describing her quiet lodger's habits, and the day after Ally describes a one-of-a-kind panel, the wall in his room has a pale gap on it. She writes to Ally, privately. Ally tells Del, and the next episode is indistinguishable from the last, because

he listens. On Day 333 he is arrested under a name that sat for three years in a missing-person file in Del's own precinct, and the sample the police took to identify his body identifies him alive.

The close.

The arrest is for the identity offences; Violet's staircase is not Ally's to promise, and she says so. The survivors' war ends where the accusation was: not reconciliation, release. The last image is Liam and Ruby in the same harbour crowd, no longer standing apart. And in the accounting, the skipper's box, kept three years in case anyone came asking, finally gets asked for: a few bland photographs of a forgotten deckhand, pinned where anyone can look. Gerald looks. He goes still at one of them, asks Ally for it, and asks her to keep it off the show. *Not yet, love. A few things I need to check first.* He hasn't kept anything from a case since he retired. He retired the year her father died.